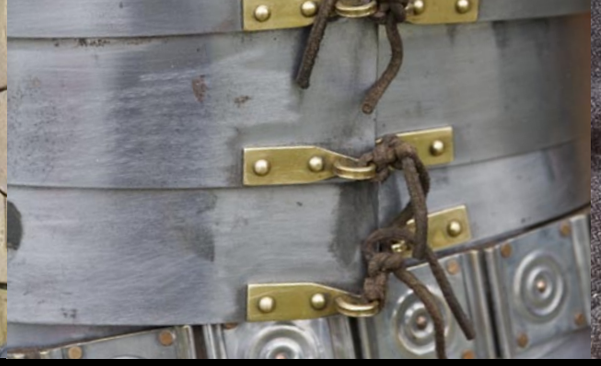




INTRODUCTION

The societies of the past had no difficulty in embracing war as a positive activity. The medieval troubadour Bertran de Born declared: "I have no such joy as … when I see both great and small fall in the ditches and on the grass: Lords, mortgage your domains, castles, cities, but never give up war!" In the contemporary world, this would at least superficially appear an unfashionable sentiment. The sheer destructiveness of modern weaponry and the vast death toll in the major conflicts of the 20th century has made war seem intolerable. And yet warfare continues to flourish, and the warrior tradition lives on. Indeed, warriors seem to have been with us since the very earliest of pre-state societies, in which, along with hunting, war was the definitive male activity. Whatever the specific pretext for combat, it constituted a necessary rite of passage for youths entering manhood, and had its essential place in the ritual life of the band or tribe. Warriors adopted costumes and equipment decorated with symbols of religious significance; combat was preceded by ceremony and sacrifice. Men of fighting age often lived apart in tightly knit groups to encourage bonding, while at the same time styles of fighting were ritualized to encourage demonstrations of individual prowess. These two superficially contradictory elements were to prove ubiquitous in the history of warfare: the bonding of fighting men in a brotherhood and the pursuit of individual glory.

BANDS OF BROTHERS

Bonding and individualism combined in one of the earliest permanent military organizations, the warband. This was a body of warriors bound by allegiance to a leader who was an acknowledged fighter of outstanding skill and courage. Its motivation was only partly material (the pursuit of plunder or land) because warfare also offered the individual his chance to improve his standing in the group. The Roman writer Tacitus, describing the German warbands of the 1st century CE, wrote that among these warriors "it is a disgrace to the chief to be surpassed in valour by his companions, to the companions not to come up to the valour of their chiefs". The warbands had to seek out conflict, says Tacitus, because "renown is easier won among perils". This attitude to warfare has been called the "warrior ethic". The warrior delights in